

Media-Hype

Self-Reinforcing News Waves, Journalistic Standards and the Construction of Social Problems

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ABSTRACT

■ News often seems to develop a life of its own, creating huge news waves on one specific story or topic. The term 'media-hype' is often used in popular debate about this kind of self-inflating media coverage, but the concept has never made it into the scientific discourse, mainly because of its implicit value judgements. However, by excluding criteria like 'exaggeration' and 'distortion' and by focusing on the process of amplification and magnification during these media-generated news waves, the concept can become a valuable tool for news research. A theoretical framework of media-hype is developed in this article, not only to analyse the specific dynamic of media-hype, but also to deal with the role it plays in the process of framing and social amplification. A content analysis of media coverage of 'senseless' street violence in the Netherlands is used to evaluate the consequences of media-hype for the role the media play in society. ■

Key Words framing, journalistic standards, media-hype, social amplification, street violence

Introduction

Every now and then the daily news media suddenly generate surprisingly high news waves on one specific story. For weeks this topic dominates the

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European Journal of Communication Copyright © 2005 SAGE Publications (London, Thousand Oaks, CA and New Delhi) www.sagepublications.com, Vol 20(4): 508–530. [10.1177/0267323105058254]

front pages, the evening news and the public forum. The news production seems to change to a higher gear, with more and more reporters hunting for 'newer' news on the story, which gains more momentum every day. In quick succession, events accumulate in the news, creating the impression that a situation has suddenly deteriorated into a real crisis. This, for instance, is the case when the media suddenly discover a 'new' type of crime, reporting new incidents every day, which in turn contributes to a growing anxiety among the public. The same process can be observed in the case where one person, a celebrity or politician, becomes the target of intensive media attention.

Each day offers new scoops, disclosures and developments: even the most trivial details can become the most important news fact of that day. Part of this news wave, especially during moral scandals, is a growing flow of allegations, speculations, accusations, denials, opinions, interpretations and, sometimes, mere rumours (Kovach and Rosenstiel, 1999). Hardly any news editor is able to resist the temptation of such an attractive story; it must be reported, because the competition is doing so, because it has consequences for main figures in the public arena and, of course, because the massive news wave itself is news.

There is something different about these news waves, compared to other mega-stories, be they on wars, natural disasters or international crises. There is a sort of *mismatch* between these news waves and the *real world* the media are supposed to cover. There is, in the words of Daniel Boorstin (1963: 40), writing about pseudo-events in the 1960s, confusion between *object* and *subject*, because the media constantly seem to switch between these roles. There is ambiguity about *covering* vs *creating* and about *cause* vs *impact*. Is it important news, or does it become important news because the media make it important? Is it real or do the media create a new reality? In this line of thinking these news waves confront us with the following problems:

1. The amount of coverage seems disproportionate considering the relevance and newsworthiness of the event at the start of the news storm. Later on, of course, the topic does indeed become important news – because the media have treated it as important news.
2. During these news waves, news coverage seems to develop a life of its own, responding mainly to the stimuli coming from within the media. These waves seem to be the result of oscillating processes within the journalistic production, making coverage more an echo of previous coverage than a mirror of events

(Kepplinger, 1994: 230). For this reason, they can be seen as media-generated news waves.

3. During some of these news waves, the link between the number of incidents reported and the actual frequency of these incidents gets lost. This has been described before, for example in the literature on crime waves (Fishman, 1981) that explores media-generated news waves on a specific kind of crime. Every new incident that seems to fit this type of crime will receive more attention than before, creating the impression that this crime is rampant. Kepplinger and Habermeier (1995) explored the impact of what they call key events in media coverage. They showed that an unusual event could trigger a temporary change in the criteria for news selection, resulting in an increase of news on similar incidents and thematically related events. News waves like this contradict the 'correspondence assumption' held by the public that the amount of coverage indicates the importance of the events and that the number of reports reflects the actual frequency of events. This kind of coverage creates 'the false impression that events accumulate and problems become more urgent' (Kepplinger and Habermeier, 1995: 389). Decision-makers taking prompt action on this kind of coverage may soon discover that their policy is built on quicksand.
4. During these news waves, the media not the events seem to be governing the coverage. The media themselves play a central role in the development of the event, the issue, the social problem or the scandal, because they create this massive news wave, which has all kinds of consequences for the social actors involved (Fiske, 1994). The media sometimes create a chain of events that would not have taken place without their involvement. In science, researchers try to avoid any interference with their research object as much as possible for the news media this kind of contamination is part of the job:

Rather, the media are actively involved in constituting the social world. By making images and information available to individuals located in distant locales, the media shape and influence the course of events, and indeed, create events that would not have existed in their absence. (Thompson, 1995: 117)

If the news media regularly operate in this way, critical questions must be asked about what this means for classic journalistic standards, which aim at producing a reliable, independent, truthful report of the

relevant events of the day (Commission on Freedom of the Press, 1947: 20–30). Furthermore, the news media also manage the public debate and perform the role of the critical watchdog, revealing problems, threats, failures and scandals. The question is: how do the media perform these roles during these media-generated news waves?

Theoretical framework

Before these questions can be addressed, the phenomenon itself must be defined and analysed. In other words, it is necessary to develop a theory on these news waves and on the consequences for the role of the media in the public domain and the construction of social problems and political issues. After all, the media are often criticized for blowing news out of proportion and for exaggerating the gravity and the scope of a social problem, like for instance ‘random violence’ (Best, 1999).

News wave or media-hype?

Critics in the popular debate often use the concept ‘hype’ or ‘media-hype’ to condemn this kind of ‘self-inflating’ media coverage, driven, in their view, by sensation-seeking or fear-mongering. Despite the popularity of this term in debates on the media, it has never made its way into scientific discourse, probably because it contains too many (varying) value judgements about the media.

Nevertheless, several aspects of the meaning of the word ‘hype’ indeed seem to cover the cargo of what is happening during these news escalations. As a verb ‘to hype (up)’ not only stands for: ‘to stimulate’; ‘to build up’; ‘to enliven,’ but also for: ‘to publicize or promote, especially by extravagant, inflated, or misleading claims’. As noun ‘a hype’ refers to ‘promotional publicity of an extravagant or contrived kind’, or ‘a blatant or sensational promotion’. It can also refer to sudden crazes in different areas, varying from culture or science to public opinion, where, without warning, everyone is under the spell of something new.

Looking at media-generated news waves several meanings of the word ‘hype’ come to mind: *amplification*, *magnification*, *exaggeration* and *distortion*. An (unusual) event triggers increased media attention; the media set their focus on this specific topic or event; they enlarge it, and by so doing evoke all kinds of social responses, which will in turn become news as well, further stimulating the news wave. Therefore, it can be argued that the term ‘media-hype’ might be a useful category for describing a media-generated news wave that seems to have its own characteristic dynamic.

The two other aspects of hype, 'exaggeration' and 'distortion', are not suitable for an analytic definition of media-hype and must therefore be excluded. 'Exaggeration' is used with two different meanings in this context:

1. The news media pay too much attention to a matter that is not very important, if not completely trivial;
2. The news media create a threat that is not consistent with the actual facts relating to the problem.

The first criterion is too subjective, it depends on personal views and ideologies that decide what is regarded as important or not. Another problem is that high levels of media attention may have many social implications, which almost inevitably will push the topic in question to the top of the public agenda.

The second meaning of exaggeration is based on the assumption that it is always possible to compare media coverage to the 'real' facts. The concept 'moral panic', defined as a state of media-generated public anxiety far in excess of what the incidence of that problem would rationally justify, is built on the same basis (Cohen, 1993; Hall et al., 1978; Goode and Ben-Yehuda, 1994; Boethius, 1995; Thompson, 1998; Jenkins, 1998). This assumption is, however, not tenable: not only because in many cases the facts are not known at the moment of the media wave, see, for example, the BSE crisis in 1996 (Ratzan, 1998), but also because the media affect the social definitions on which the 'real' facts are established. Comparing media coverage with statistics on violent crime can be a pitfall, because intensive media reports on violence may lead to changing perceptions among the public, to an increase in the reporting of violence, to more criminal investigations and ultimately to rising figures on violence. What are the 'real' facts here?

If a 'reality check' cannot be part of a definition of the media-generated news wave, this leaves us with the remaining meanings of the word hype: amplification and magnification. Consequently, a definition of media-hype can only be based on the specific dynamic of a news wave, without an a priori denouncement of the phenomenon and excluding criteria like exaggeration and distortion. This approach can be compared with the way Smelser defined panic as: 'a collective flight based on hysterical belief' (Smelser, 1963: 131). It is possible to define a state of panic without taking into account whether or not the panic was justified (there was no fire), or whether there was a negative outcome (people got killed). Shibutani (1966) defined the concept 'rumour' without any

reference to the truthfulness of the message, creating a new approach to the phenomenon of improvised news.

The same should be done in the case of media-generated news waves. Although 'reality' cannot be part of a definition of media-hype, that does not rule out a debate on the consequences of this dynamic for the construction of social problems. In that debate the picture painted by media-hype coverage can of course be compared with other (scientific) constructions of reality. The word 'media-hype' is suitable because during these news escalations the media *do* stimulate, amplify and magnify, contributing to what in research related to risk issues is described as 'the process of social amplification'. This refers to the chain of events in which a specific risk is magnified, causing in turn all kinds of secondary social, political and economic consequences (Kasperson et al., 1987; Slovic, 2000). The media belong to the most important 'stations' of amplification by framing risk messages and transmitting them to the public (Pidgeon et al., 2003; Petts et al., 2001).

The dynamics of media-hype

An analysis of the features of these sudden news waves shows the following patterns.

Positive feedback loops Regular news coverage follows an event: journalists report the facts, offer opinion and organize the debate. After a while, the topic becomes less newsworthy and media attention will diminish. In some cases, however, the coverage goes on, more or less independently from the actual events. 'The media represent a self-referential system which under certain conditions loses contact with the outside world and reacts mainly to its own activities' (Kepplinger and Habermeier, 1995: 373). News production seems to develop a life of its own, boosted several times over by the same process of reinforcement: it becomes even more important news, because it is regarded as important news. Positive feedback loops feed the news (van Ginneken, 1999: 94) over and over again.

A key event This chain reaction is triggered by a key event that receives more attention than usual – for whatever reason: special ingredients perhaps, for instance a mythical story (Lule, 2001), or because of a lack of more important news during slow news days. This implies that not only shocking events can act as trigger, but also incidents (of violence for instance) that would under other circumstances never have made the main headlines. A key event can be a genuine event, independent of news

coverage, like car accidents or earthquakes (Kepplinger and Habermeier, 1995: 374), but it might also be an interview, a speech, an official warning (regarding health risks) or, as often happens in scandals, a startling disclosure by investigative reporters. The question is: can the event be framed in such a way that it draws more attention? Does it offer enough clues for follow-up stories? Can it be linked to controversial issues of the moment? Sources who are in a position to label the event can have a considerable impact on the subsequent news coverage (Manning, 2001). 'Such triggers help the mass media frame an issue and also help the issue catch the public's attention' (Dearing and Rogers, 1996: 78). In the long run, these events can develop into an icon, a prototype (Brosius and Eps, 1995; Bennett and Lawrence, 1995) that is capable of condensing a complex problem into one striking image.

The news theme The next step is the quick dissemination of a news theme across the different news desks. 'A news theme is a unifying concept. It presents a specific news event, or a number of such events in terms of a broader concept' (Fishman, 1981: 102). This concept, which is of course based on the original labelling of the event, becomes the starting point for follow-up reporting: it structures the hunt for newer news about the case in question by defining the angle of the story and the kind of sources that are needed (Brosius and Eps, 1995: 395). Journalism is a highly self-referential system: news is what other media consider newsworthy. This leads to a high degree of uniformity in the news selection and a pressure on every news desk to join the pack (Kitzinger and Reilly, 1997).

Lowering of news thresholds The impact of a news theme on media coverage can be described as a temporary lowering of the news thresholds for any event or statement that can be related to the central news theme:

The mass media are in a powerful position to synthesize seemingly fragmented and unconnected situations and create what appear to be widespread phenomena . . . [they] strive to convert stories about particular cases into examples of a general situation. (Kielbowics and Scherer, 1986: 81)

This leads to a flow of thematically related news. Selective perception prevails; news that seems to confirm the chosen frame will be reported, while other facts and opinions are neglected or at best marginalized. This explains the hunt for comparable cases that is often seen: any recent or past incident that fits this theme will receive (renewed) media attention. If the match is not perfect, comparable cases will be reinterpreted to fit, thereby reinforcing the chosen frame. In this way, the media create a wave of comparable incidents in the news, giving the public the impression

that events accumulate and that problems get worse every day. Inevitably, this growing news wave will stimulate all kinds of reactions in society, which in turn will fan the flames in the public arena. The result is a constant reinforcement of a specific frame of reference, marginalizing other perspectives (Noelle-Neuman and Mathes, 1987: 402).

Interactive media momentum This huge news hunt generates all kinds of responses in society, varying from individuals reporting similar experiences to statements from official sources and interest groups, using the opportunity to promote their views or to announce actions. 'In addition to such self-referential momentum, the media also contribute to the build-up of interactive momentum' (Kitzinger and Reilly, 1997: 335). All these actions and reactions feed the news wave, reinforcing the newsworthiness of the news theme.

Decline of the news wave Following the sharp rise in the amount of coverage, it eventually declines: sources for follow-up news slowly become exhausted, reporters' interest in the topic reaches saturation point, other news becomes more important, and within days the news wave can be over. The decreasing news value of the original theme will raise the news thresholds for similar events or thematically related news. The upward spiral of media attention goes downward until the topic disappears completely from the news. In the long run, however, news waves in the same area can be expected, because of the public's changed perceptions and a higher sensitivity regarding the topic. An indication of this is the fact that food and health scares and sexual abuse scandals seem to crop up in clusters (Fowler, 1991; Jenkins, 1992).

Definition of media-hype

In identifying these patterns, media-hype can therefore be defined as a media-generated, wall-to-wall news wave, triggered by one specific event and enlarged by the self-reinforcing processes within the news production of the media. During a media-hype, the sharp rise in news stories is the result of making news, instead of reporting news events, and covering media-triggered social responses, instead of reporting developments that would have taken place without media interference.

The following criteria can be used to identify media-hype.

- The sudden materialization of a news wave, which rises steeply and fades away slowly and is not linked to the frequency of any

actual events as reported,¹ and which is based on consonant choices in the newsrooms of the different media, whose separate coverage will demonstrate the same wave.

- The existence of a key event: there is a clear starting point for the news wave, an event that receives more attention than comparable events, for whatever reason.
- The media are making the news instead of reporting events by: reporting comparable incidents and linking them to the key event; reporting thematically related news such as features, analyses and opinions.
- There is an interaction between the media and social actors resulting in: increased coverage of social action triggered by the news wave; increased coverage of reactions from social actors.

To be considered a media-hype, it seems reasonable that a news wave conforms at least to the following criteria: a key event; a consonant news wave; a sudden increase in reports on comparable cases; and a strong rise of thematically related news.

Nevertheless, one can identify differences between the news waves conforming to these hype criteria. Sometimes the media go into one case in depth, reporting every detail; sometimes they widen the ground they cover by reporting all kinds of events under the umbrella of the same news theme. This is why a distinction is made between *magnifying* and *enlarging* media-hypes. Coverage of scandals belongs to the first category of media-hype, and news waves on new social problems to the second.

Amplification of social problems

Conditions have first to be defined as problematic before they are recognized by society as social problems, scandals or crises (Best, 1995). This collective definition is not a given, but the result of the efforts of politics, interest groups and social movements. As messengers and managers of the public arena, the media play an important role in this process of social construction. Since media-hype can magnify or enlarge specific problems in a short period, it is relevant to focus on the link between media-hype and the construction of social problems.

Intensive media attention not only brings a topic to the top of the public agenda, it can also bring to the fore different perspectives on the problem at hand. A media-hype triggered by a key event and feeding on the self-reinforcing processes of news production, expands one specific frame, which becomes dominant in the public arena. The news hunt is

characterized by confirmation and consonance. One frame is reinforced over and over again, because every incident or statement that seems to confirm the dominant news theme will receive more attention than before. As a consequence of the self-referentiality in the news all media-outlets will follow the same trail.

One result of media-hype will be an expansion of the definition of the problem. Because new similar incidents are reported daily and because all kind of news is linked to the news theme, the scope of the problem gets broader by the day. Also, during a scandal the crisis appears more critical, as new details are revealed, confirming the negative morality of the main characters. In this way, media-hype plays an important role in the process of social amplification, because 'if men define situations as real, they are real in their consequences' (Thomas and Thomas, 1928: 572). In this respect, media coverage can be a self-fulfilling prophecy. A situation becomes a real crisis because it is described as a crisis; a condition becomes an important social problem because it is described in terms of a sudden deterioration of the situation. In this way media-hype can create new realities, independent from other non-mediated realities.

Outline of the research

The tenability of these theories on media-hype and the role it plays in the construction of social problems were explored by analysing media coverage in three different areas: violence, sexual abuse and health risks.

- Between 1997 and 2000, the Dutch were shocked by a series of incidents of street violence, quickly labelled 'senseless violence'. Several news waves may be identified as media-hype contributing to the social construction of this new type of street crime.
- Sexual abuse has also been a huge topic in the news over the past decades. An analysis of this coverage tries to reconstruct the role of the media and media-hype in the long-term development of this social problem.
- The aftermath of the plane crash in the Bijlmermeer in Amsterdam in 1992 gave rise to intensive media coverage on the presumed link between the health complaints of rescue workers and Bijlmer inhabitants and the (postulated) toxic cargo of the El Al Boeing. This part of the research explores the connection between the attribution of health problems to one cause and the

huge news waves in which one specific frame was reinforced over and again (see Yzermans et al., 2003; Vasterman et al., 2005).

In this article, only one case study is reported in depth: the emergence of 'senseless violence' in the Netherlands between 1997 and 2000. Using quantitative and qualitative content analysis of newspaper reports, the following questions are explored:

- To what extent do these news waves on senseless violence match the criteria for a media-hype? Is there a key event, followed by a wave of similar reports in the news? Are the media generating a wave of thematically related news?
- If so, what are the consequences of these news waves for the social construction of this 'new' crime problem? Do the media indeed propagate one frame in which the definition of the problem becomes broader and broader?
- And does this construction differ from the scientific data on the gravity and the scope of this kind of street violence?²
- What was nature of the media coverage on the activities of social actors – the new social movement and their silent marches against senseless violence?

Case study on senseless violence

During the 1990s, the Dutch nation was shocked by the death of young people falling victim to what was labelled 'senseless violence'. They were innocent victims, apparently killed for no reason by unknown persons roaming the streets at night. The social outrage was expressed in several silent protest marches, attended by thousands of people and covered live by the national media.

The first news wave – when the label 'senseless violence' was first coined – took place in September 1997, after the death of 30-year-old Meindert Tjoelker, killed in a night-time fight that flared up because the victim had criticized a group of vandals; the second wave happened after the trial against the offenders in January 1998; the third, in January 1999 after two girls were shot at random when someone fired at the door of a cafe they had been thrown out of; while the last case happened in January 2000, when a student died two days after being beaten up on a railway platform by a group of youths for no apparent reason.

Tjoelker, who became the media icon in the coverage on senseless violence, would probably never have reached national media attention

without the remarkable appeal by the Leeuwarder police commissioner to commemorate Tjoelker one week later by a minute's silence to protest against this 'growing senseless violence' – thereby coining a new concept of victims of violence: citizens getting killed for doing their civic duty and intervening in anti-social situations. Another case, one year before Tjoelker, was in retrospect also linked to senseless violence: in 1996 in Amsterdam a student had been beaten to death trying to protect people who were being attacked by a drunken hooligan. A few weeks before Tjoelker died, the neon sign 'HELP' had been installed at the spot as a memorial.

In the week between Tjoelker's death and the evening of the public commemoration, media coverage increased daily, thus emphasizing the importance of the meeting, which was to be covered live by two television channels. This was the first example of public mourning in the Netherlands, comparable to what happened after the death of Diana in the UK, two weeks before. On the spot of the fatal incident, a sea of flowers grew and the meeting on the Friday evening, where the mayor gave a speech, was attended by thousands of people.

Qualitative analysis of the media coverage

In the week after the death of Meindert Tjoelker, the media suddenly discovered senseless violence everywhere: all kinds of (fatal) incidents, new, recent or in the past, were described as typical examples of this new kind of violence. The element of intervening in the anti-social behaviour of other people disappeared rather quickly from the definition of the concept, making it possible to include completely different acts of violence under the same common denominator.

The result was a wave of reporting violent incidents in the Dutch media during several weeks after the key event. Some newspaper articles referred to an 'explosion' or a 'spiralling epidemic' of senseless violence in Dutch society. Emotional stories with personal details about the victims also became an important part of the news wave, as well as examples of public outrage and political debate.

In the slipstream of all this media attention on senseless violence, social actors seized the moment to advance their interests. Politicians debated on drastic action to be taken by the government, while local councils decided to introduce camera surveillance and a zero tolerance policy. The outrage about violence also triggered initiatives like the Twelve Cities Debate (a series of conferences), the National Foundation against Senseless Violence and the national Day against Violence, which

received huge media attention. Several relatives of victims came forward as crusaders against senseless violence, and were frequently interviewed by the media. Public opinion polls in the weeks after the much-publicized cases showed a remarkable increase in the number of people saying they felt unsafe in the public domain (Dijkstra, 1999).

In the years following, this pattern of reporting consistent with media-hype re-emerged on three occasions: incidents of violence developed into a key event, because they were covered in such a way that they attracted more and more media attention. These news flows consisted of a wave of reports of similar violent occurrences, public outrage and political polemics about how to handle this problem.

Despite intensive media attention on senseless violence between 1997 and 2000, not all fatal cases of street violence triggered media-hype. By comparing three similar cases of senseless violence, each time followed by silent protest marches, the question was explored as to why some incidents became the object of a media-hype, while others were almost completely ignored. The main factor seems to be the initial framing of the incident as a typical example of senseless violence. This labelling immediately after the incident structures the journalistic follow-up. When authorities qualified a fatal incident as a 'road rage' incident or 'a gang fight', there was no strong incentive for the media to pay much attention, in contrast with cases that were presented as typical examples of senseless violence. The fact that some of the victims who were 'ignored' belonged to ethnic minorities may also have played a role: not because of racism, but because the media have less access to these communities. This gives people less power to influence the framing of the incident of violence.

Between 1997 and 2000, more than 15 silent marches were held to commemorate victims and to protest against senseless violence. Only three of these protests received massive media attention and live coverage on national television. The fact that tens of thousands attended these meetings made them exceptionally newsworthy; however, the media themselves played a crucial role in the days before the march, comparable to the role of the Belgian media in the days before the White March during the Dutroux scandal in Brussels in 1996 (Walgrave and Manssens, 1998). Media coverage in these cases was huge, emotional and activating, probably mobilizing many people to participate. But it is important to note that in this kind of process of escalation there is no simple chain of cause and effect. There is a constant interaction between media coverage and the activities of the social actors.

Quantitative analysis of media coverage

The preceding description gives a strong indication that the news waves on senseless violence were in fact media generated, but do they conform to all the criteria typical of media-hype: the sudden materialization of a news wave; the existence of a key event; the creation of a wave of reports on similar incidents referring to the key event; and the flow of thematically related news, containing social responses to previous coverage?

In order to test this, a content analysis was carried out using all newspaper reports between September 1997 and September 2000 on senseless violence (1010 articles) and the three key events (955 articles³) that were published in the five national dailies. Each article was classified on the basis of the headline, the lead and a context sentence only, and not on the basis of the whole article. The decision to focus on national dailies was not only based on practical reasons (availability in digital databases), but also because these five newspapers play a central role in the Dutch press landscape and because television news will probably show the same patterns in news selection.

In order to classify the collection of news articles, different 'layers' of news were identified. The first distinction is the difference between *incident-related* news and *thematically related* news. The former category is defined as factual reports about actual events: the *key event* and *similar events*. The latter is defined as reports that are not factual but only related to the central news theme in the construction: background articles, features, interviews, announcements, etc. During a media-hype it is expected that thematically related news will dominate very soon after the start of the news wave.

The category 'similar reports' is divided into news on similar incidents that either *were* or *were not* compared to the key event, termed 'compared' and 'isolated' incidents respectively. During a media-hype one can expect the media to report on more similar incidents and to link them to the key event and/or the news theme.

The category 'thematically related news' is divided into either 'media-' or 'source-generated' reports. The former covers features, opinion and marginal references to the news theme, the latter opinions (reactions) and actions of sources. During a media-hype it can be expected that within the thematically related news, media-generated reports will dominate, thereby indicating the leading role of the media (see Table 1).

By counting the number of reports in these different news categories at different stages of the news wave (see Figure 1), it is possible to

Table 1 Classification system for categories and subcategories in news waves

<i>Incident-related news</i>		<i>Thematically related news</i>	
Key event	Similar incidents	Media-generated	Source-generated
Actual events	• Isolated incidents • Incidents compared to key event	• Opinion • Background • Marginal references	• Action • Reaction

determine which part of the news wave was generated by the factual coverage of events and which part was generated by the news-making activities of the media. The number of articles in the categories media- or source-generated give an indication respectively of the active role of the media or the social actors responding to the coverage. Also, it is possible to look at the degree of consistency between different media concerning their news choices.

Results

The dissection of the different news layers in the news on senseless violence showed the following:

- Coverage on senseless violence came in four different waves, becoming larger in number each time.
- Each news wave had an act of violence as the key event triggering a growing media attention, except for the one wave (January 1998) which was triggered by the sentencing of the offenders in the Tjoelker case.⁴
- Each news wave peaked a few days after the event, with a slow decline over the following weeks.
- Each news wave was ‘wall-to-wall’: four out of five newspapers paid more or less the same amount of attention at the same frequency.
- In three out of four news waves, thematically related news quickly outnumbered incident-related news.
- In all cases, the newspaper reported more similar incidents of violence in the weeks after the key event.

- In two of the four news waves, the sources played an active role in generating thematically related news, while in the other two waves the media dominated.
- Within the category media-generated news, opinion outnumbered background articles in three out of four news waves.

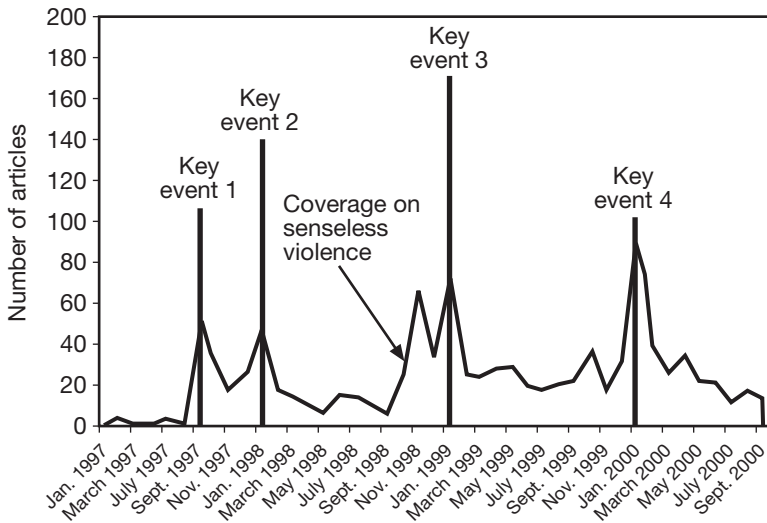


Figure 1 Coverage of senseless violence per month in five national dailies, Jan 1997–Sept 2000

Looking at the different criteria for a media-hype, the conclusion is that one news wave (key event number 3 in 1999) matches all criteria (see Figure 2), two news waves (key event number 1 in 1997 and number 2 in 1998) match almost all criteria, while the last wave (number 3 in 2000) does not conform to the picture of media-hype, because a large part of the news wave was in fact incident-related news. Each news wave turned out to be bigger in numbers of articles than the previous one, which suggests a cumulative effect.

Figure 3 shows the percentages of thematically related news for each news wave during the first four weeks. The 1998 and 1999 waves show a very large share of this kind of news (90 percent), while the last wave, in 2000, as already indicated, is largely an incident-related news wave.

In summary, regarding media coverage of street violence one can speak of media-hype: key events triggered waves of news in which all media participated. All newspapers showed more or less the same frequency and number of articles. They offered a lot more thematically

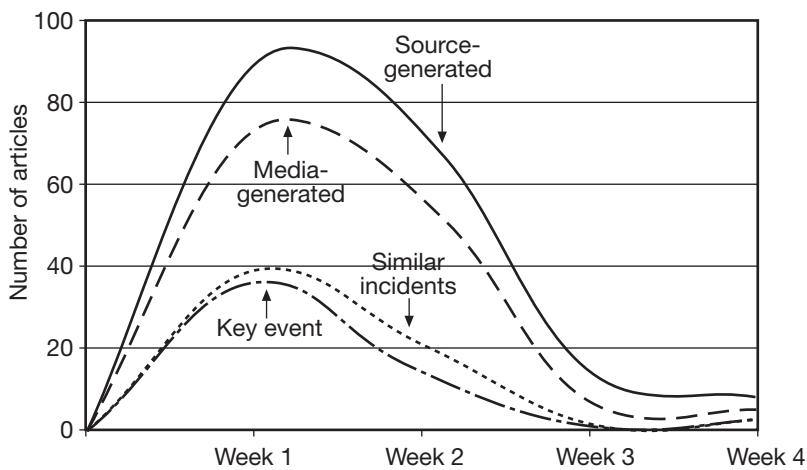


Figure 2 Typical example of a media-hype news wave: senseless violence, key event number 3, January 1999

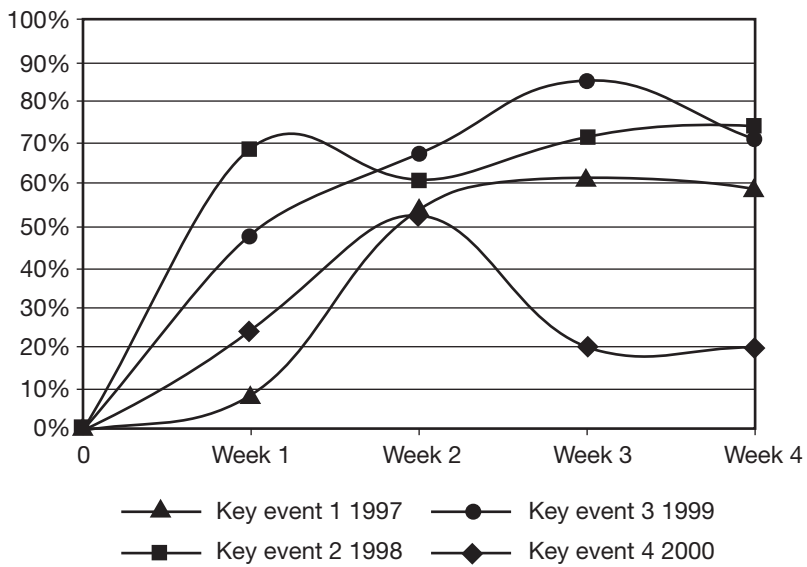


Figure 3 Percentage of thematically related news of total news wave during the four news waves in the first four weeks

related than incident-related news. Furthermore, the newspapers all reported more similar incidents in the weeks following the key event, thereby creating a wave of incidents in the news, suggesting a sudden increase. In one case (key event number 2: sentencing of offenders), the

role of the social actors – sources creating news – turned out to be a relevant factor in the news wave.

The social construction of a new crime problem

The analysis of the newspaper reports on senseless violence showed that the media played an active role in the construction of this presumably 'new' crime problem and a mobilizing role in the social outrage and the silent marches. Overall, the media created the threatening image of purely random, pointless violence that could hit anyone, anywhere (for similar examples on random violence in the US, see Best, 1999).

The facts⁵ on violent crime in the Netherlands show a different story, however: this kind of violence is not new, it is not on the rise, and fights ending in fatalities (like the key events) are quite exceptional (Beke et al., 1999, 2001). The birth of the concept of senseless violence is an example of the redefinition of isolated incidents into a new and frightening social problem. Criminological research has shown that in many cases the roles of attacker and victim are often interchangeable and that there is always a reason for the fight, however futile it might seem in the eyes of the public. Beke et al. also point out that senseless violence is a useless concept for investigating the scope of the problem, because it lacks a clear definition and because it is merely a moral category used to condemn violence.

A more general pattern seems to be that media coverage on 'new' crime problems contributes to the broadening of the concept by reporting all kinds of violence under the same denominator, fuelling public outrage, which in turn feeds media coverage and so on (Zillmann and Brosius, 2000). In this way, media-hype plays an important role in the creation of a spiral of social amplification. A cumulative series of ever-greater media-hypes add to the general impression that this kind of crime is rampant. Media-hypes are created on the basis of one frame that guides the hunt for more news and presents all the facts and views from the same perspective.

Media-hype and journalistic standards

Is the way the media operate during media-hype in conflict with the professional standards of a socially responsible press: reliability (attribution to sources and verification of facts); fairness (to sources and the public); balance (giving a voice to different perspectives); independence (no commercial or political dependency); distance (impartiality); relevance (informing on relevant developments and social problems); and

social responsibility (self-reflection and accountability) (see McQuail, 1992; Kovach and Rosenstiel, 1999, 2001)?

This research shows that in many cases media-hype violates these journalistic standards. Media-hype is based on self-reinforcing processes in which one specific frame guides the media hunt for ever more facts and opinions that confirm the established frame. Dissenting information is ignored or trivialized. These positive feedback loops lead to a reinforcement of the original frame, making this perspective the only one that seems socially relevant. In fact, due to the huge news wave accompanying it, this frame will become the most dominant frame in the public domain.

Media-hype is based on pack journalism: every news desk is forced to join the pack, which leads to a high degree of uniformity in the news selection. This clashes with the professional standard of independent news choice.

A typical feature of media-hype is the wave of comparable incidents in the news, which creates the false impression that events are accumulating and that the problem is getting worse. This kind of reporting is conflicting with journalistic standards such as reliability and balance.

Due to media-hype, a social problem can appear to reach crisis proportions, forcing social actors, especially the authorities, to take drastic and hasty action. This, again, reinforces the concern among the public, because the action confirms the existence of a real crisis. And this, of course, triggers a new wave of media attention. This chain reaction will fuel the amplification again and again, leading to the well-known paradox that the more action society takes the more visible the problem will get, reinforcing social concern. Reporters should be aware of the fact that media-hype gives a boost to this often uncontrollable amplification process, which might not be a rational way for a society to deal with social problems.

This research shows that media-hype can create unrealistic images of immediate threat and risk, be it senseless violence, paedophile killers or risk issues like depleted uranium (Vasterman et al., 2005). This image is based on broad definitions, exaggerated estimates and the projection of one extreme case (key event) to a whole range of events. Hyped coverage leads to an inflation of catchall concepts like senseless violence, creating the impression that the social problem is rising to epidemic proportions. Professional journalistic standards, on the other hand, expect the media to give a thorough estimation of the scope of a problem.

Discussion

Although this research was not based on a hypothesis of an increase in media-hype in recent years, several developments indicate that this might be the case. Increasingly, coverage seems to be dominated by an endless series of scandals, affairs and media events, each time triggering even larger news waves.

Another development (in the Netherlands) is the growth in the number of competing media fighting for the same news. The result is a huge increase in the magnitude of the coverage on a specific topic. Increasing competition leads to more uniformity, not more diversity, in news coverage. The 24-hour news cycle, with all its deadlines, forces the media to act immediately and report news without thorough fact checking. This easily leads to the domination of one frame in the coverage at the expense of others. Another development is the rise of media outlets based on a mix of news and entertainment. For these media, the hunt for commercially interesting news becomes more important than journalistic standards like truthfulness and reliability. This competition forces the traditional journalistic media to pay more attention to topics like crime, celebrity and lifestyle, and to publish news which is characterized more by emotion, human interest and primary reactions. More research is necessary into the factors promoting the frequency and intensity of media-hype. Unfortunately, media-hype too often goes by without reflection on the content of the news and the consequences for public opinion and political decision-making.

Conclusion

The concept media-hype of course needs refining and more empirical backup, but it can become a valuable tool because it separates research into the dynamics of media-generated news waves from the ideologically inspired debates about exaggeration and distortion. A news wave is not a media-hype because it exaggerates or distorts reality, but because it is a special kind of news wave created by the self-reinforcing processes in the news production.

Notes

1. This refers to events reported by media or other professional data collectors like census bureaus or scientific researchers. This criterion does not imply a return to the 'reality check' argument. The frequency of incidents in the media is compared to 'relative' and not 'absolute' data from other sources.

2. The kind of consequences of media-hype for the social construction of a crime problem is not part of the definition of media-hype.
3. These two data collections cannot be totalled, because they partly overlap each other.
4. In November 1998 the final conference of the Twelve Cities Debate on senseless violence also generated a news wave. This one was not analysed in detail, because this part of the research project focused on news waves triggered by genuine events (Kepplinger and Habermeier, 1995) like violent incidents or court convictions. Other parts of the research focus on other kinds of key events like the parliamentary enquiry in the case of the Bijlmer airplane crash.
5. These 'facts' are also the result of a specific construction of reality, based on definitions and observation methods. In this study, different perspectives are compared to explore the effect of media-hype on the social construction of a problem.

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